
Natural Vegetation

What is natural vegetation?

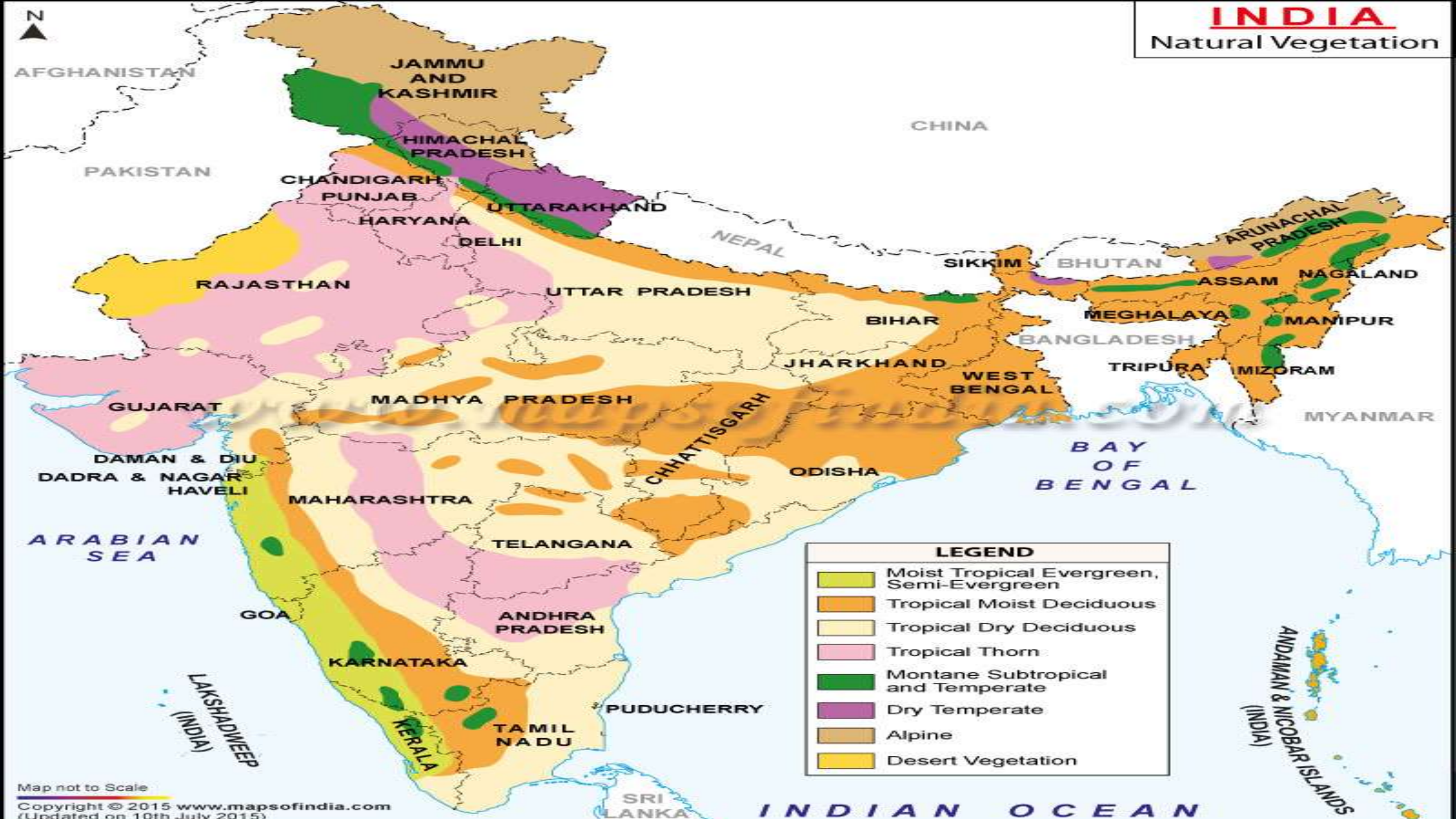
- It refers to a plant community which has grown naturally without human aid and has been left undisturbed by humans for a long time (also called as virgin vegetation). Or in common parlance forests or jungles etc.

- Cultivated crops and fruits, orchards form part of vegetation but not natural vegetation
- The virgin vegetation, which are purely Indian are known as endemic or indigenous species but those which have come from outside India are termed as exotic plants.
- The term flora is used to denote plants of a particular region or period. The species of animals are referred to as fauna.

- The following are the principal types of natural vegetation in India:
- (1) Tropical Evergreen Rain Forests,
- (2) Deciduous or Monsoon Type of Forests,
- (3) Dry Deciduous Forests and Scrubs,
- (4) Semi Desert and Desert Vegetation,

  (5) Tidal or Mangrove Forests and

- Forestry in India is a significant rural industry and a major environmental resource. India is one of the ten most forest-rich countries of the world. Together, India and these other 9 countries account for 67 percent of total forest area of the world.


INDIA
Natural Vegetation
N
AFGHANISTAN
PAKISTAN
CHINA
NEPAL
BHUTAN
BANGLADESH
MYANMAR
SRI LANKA
JAMMU AND KASHMIR
HIMACHAL PRADESH
CHANDIGARH
PUNJAB
HARYANA
DELHI
UTTARAKHAND
RAJASTHAN
UTTAR PRADESH
BIHAR
SIKKIM
ARUNACHAL PRADESH
ASSAM
NAGALAND
MEGHALAYA
MANIPUR
TRIPURA
MIZORAM
JHARKHAND
WEST BENGAL
GUJARAT
MADHYA PRADESH
CHHATTISGARH
ODISHA
DAMAN & DIU
DADRA & NAGAR HAVELI
MAHARASHTRA
TELANGANA
ANDHRA PRADESH
GOA
KARNATAKA
KERALA
TAMIL NADU
PUDUCHERRY
LAKSHADWEEP (INDIA)
ANDAMAN & NICOBAR ISLANDS (INDIA)
BAY OF BENGAL
ARABIAN SEA
INDIAN OCEAN
LEGEND
Moist Tropical Evergreen, Semi-Evergreen
Tropical Moist Deciduous
Tropical Dry Deciduous
Tropical Thorn
Montane Subtropical and Temperate
Dry Temperate
Alpine
Desert Vegetation
Map not to Scale
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- According to International conventions every country should have about 33% of its area under forests.
- The world average of forest cover is 26.6%.
- Mangroves in India are about 0.14% of the geographical area of country and are found in deltaic plains
- Per capita forest and tree cover in India is 0.08 hectare.

Class	Area (sq km)	Percentage of Geographical Area
Forest Cover		
Very Dense Forest	99,278	3.02
Moderately Dense Forest	3,08,472	9.38
Open Forest	3,04,499	9.26
Total Forest Cover*	**7,12,249**	**21.67**
Tree Cover	95,027	2.89
Total Forest and Tree Cover	**8,07,276**	**24.56**
Scrub	46,297	1.41
Non-Forest#	25,28,923	76.92
Total Geographic Area	**32,87,469**	**100.00**

* Includes 4,975 sq km under Mangrove Cover

\# Non-forest includes Tree Cover (Percentage rounded off)

- **1. Tropical Ever-green Forests**
- Distribution
- (i) Rainy slopes of Western Ghats
- (ii) NE India except Arunachal Pradesh
- (iii) Eastern parts of West Bengal and Orissa.
- (iv) Andaman & Nicobar islands

- Climatic Conditions
- (i) Rainfall > 200 cms.
- (ii) Relative humidity > 70%
- (iii) Average temperature is about 24º C.
- (iv) Hot and humid climate.

- **Characteristics**
- (i) Height of trees is 40 to 60 metres.
- (ii) Under growth is very less
- (iii)There is no distinct season of sheding of leaves and forests remain green throughout the year.
- (iv)Leaves are dark green and broad.
- Species of trees
- Mahogany, Mahua, Bamboo, Canes, Ironwood, Kadam, Irul, Jamun, Hopea, Rubber tree, Toon, Telsur, etc.

- **2. Tropical Moist Deciduous Forests**
- Distribution
- (i) Eastern parts of Sahyadris (Western Ghats)
- (ii) North eastern part of Peninsula.
- (iii) Middle and lower Ganga Valley
- (iv) Foot hills of Himalaya in Bhabar and Terai region
- (v) These cover about 20% India’s forest area

- **Climatic Conditions**
- (i) 100 to 200 cms rainfall per annum
- (ii) Moderate temperature.
- **Characteristics**
- (i) 30 to 40 m high trees
- (ii) Due to deficiency of water they shed their leaves in spring (onset of summer)
- (iii) High undergrowth.
- **Species of Trees**
- Sal, Teak, Arjun, Mulberry, Kusum, Sandalwood, Siris, Haldi, Khair, Mango, Banyan tree etc.

- 3. Tropical Dry Deciduous Forests
- Distribution
- (i) Large parts of Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh
- (ii) Parts of Punjab, Haryana and Eastern parts of Rajasthan
- (iii) Northern and western parts of M.P.
- (iv) Tamil Nadu
- (v) Southern parts of U.P.

- **Climatic Conditions**
- (i) 50 to 100 cms rain fall
- (ii) Moderate humidity
- **Characteristics**
- (i) 6 to 15 metres high trees
- (ii) Roots are thick and long
- (iii) Bark is thick to avoid undue evaporation
- (iv) Distinct season of sheding of leaves in onset of summer.
- **Species of Trees**
- Teak, Sal, Babool, Kikar, Mango, Acacia, Neem, Sheesham, etc.

- **Dry Forests or Arid Forests**
- **Distribution**
- (i) Rajasthan and adjoining areas of Haryana, Gujarat and Punjab.
- (ii) Rain Shadow area of Peninsular India
- **Climatic Conditions**
- (i) Low rainfall (less than 50 cms per annum)
- (ii) Relative humidity is less

- **Characteristics**
- (i) Thorny Vegetation
- (ii) Roots are very long
- (iii) Leaves are small
- **Species of Trees**
- Cactus, Thorny bushes, Kikar, Babool, Date palms, Acacia, Khair, Euphorbias, etc.

- 5. Mountainous Forest or Himalayan Forests
- Due to increase of altitude the temperature decreases hence Himalayan forests contain all the varieties of world except equatorial forests.
- This vegetation belt occurs at relatively 300 m more height in eastern Himalayas than in western Himalayas due to following facts:
- (a)Eastern Himalayas receives more rainfall than western Himalayas
- (b)Eastern Himalayas are nearer to sea and equator than western Himalayas.

- Important species of trees are Sal, Teak, Chir, Deodar, Oak, Olive, Chestnut, Conifers, Spruce and Lirch etc.
- Himalayas are very rich in resource potential

- 6. **Tidal Forests or Mangrove Forests or Swampy Forest**
- These are found in deltaic plain along the coast of sea.
- These are proved to be one of the best species of trees which maintain healthy ecological balance.
- These can survive in salty as well as in fresh water
- These help in formation of delta by blocking the sediments and prevent sea shore from erosion by blocking tidal waves.
- Important species are Sundari, Mangroves, Bruguiera, Sonneratia, Agar, Keora, Nipa etc.